(lowest bidder) system of tendering, and that the only way out of this quagmire was through indigenization.

On 6 May 2020, I went to the Prime Minister's residence yet again, my third visit in five months. I entered the conference hall and laid out the briefing folders at each seat. As the attendees started walking in one by one—Cabinet and Foreign Secretary, CDS, NSA, Ministers of Defence, Home and External Affairs—my mind flashed back to the Staff College Course where we had had a class on Higher Defence Organization and what constituted the Cabinet Committee on Security. As they came in and took their seats awaiting the arrival of the PM, it suddenly struck me that this was the very CCS I had studied almost three decades ago, never imagining that one day, I would be part of that august body. I would brief the CCS numerous times, though the last meeting that I attended in March 2022 was not so pleasant.

The agenda that day was about Doklam, where more developments had taken place that needed urgent attention. However, before that, I brought to everyone's attention an emerging situation in Eastern Ladakh, particularly in the Area of Patrolling Point 14 (PP-14) in the Galwan Valley. A day earlier, on 5 May, there had been a tense face-off between the PLA and our troops at PP-14.[10] It is providential that we had detected this move as the Army Commander, Lt Gen YK Joshi, accompanied by the Corps Commander, Lt Gen Harinder Singh, had been on an aerial reconnaissance mission and had spotted this surreptitious build-up. Suitably alerted, we had mobilized our forces, resulting in the face-off that continued throughout the night, with lots of jostling and fisticuffs. There were no major injuries to either side, and it was at par with similar face-offs in other areas. Since the NSA, Shri Ajit Doval, was to speak to his counterpart (as

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